will be elusive. Political parties need to prepare to govern, alongside campaigning to get elected. Once the election results are in, every day lost in establishing the team and kicking off a portfolio of reforms is a costly delay. We are doing too little transition planning in Indian politics.

When out of power, political parties should have a shadow cabinet. There should be a sustained process of engagement with think tanks, academic institutions, data sets and intellectuals, in order to cogitate about what is going wrong. The emphasis in an opposition party should be not just on criticizing what the ruling party has done, but on developing a set of plans for what would be done when in power.

The incumbent ruling party equally faces this problem. At year 5, a successful ruling team is jaded, and an unsuccessful ruling team is demoralized. Yet, it needs to think through the possibility of re-election, and find the energy for transition planning.

This preparatory work would be particularly valuable when it is fed into the manifesto of the political party and, when coalition governments are formed, the negotiation for a common minimum programme. The paragraphs in such documents matter disproportionately, but receive inadequate attention ahead of time.

Long-range thinking and capacity building are required in each political party to develop the capability to succeed in the event of winning elections. When such developmental work is not done, ahead of time, we translate remarkable election outcomes into failures on policy.

Playing the long game

A cult of *jald baazi* is taking root in India. This is the notion that a problem can be understood in a few days, and solved in a few weeks. Powerful policymakers tend to whip up a frenzy of getting things done quickly. Every expert in India has gone through the surreal experience of being ignored for years, and then asked to deliver a reform document overnight.